



Tokyo-Yokohama railroad

This poster, dating from 1875, celebrates the Tokyo terminus of the railroad, built in 1872 with the aid of foreign engineers. The image was issued only seven years after the Meiji Restoration opened Japan to foreign ideas.

teachers. A modern mint was set up, and in 1882 the Bank of Japan opened with a standardized decimal currency based on the yen.

Population shift

Perhaps the greatest symbol of Japan's modernization was the railway. The first was opened in October 1872, and within 15 years 1,000 miles (1,600 km) of track had been laid. It had a profound effect on the country and its economy.

Suburbs grew as people now lived away from their place of work, and the age of commuting had begun.

SHOGUN Prior to 1868, shoguns ruled Japan. They were hereditary leaders who commanded armies that included a warrior class known as the samurai.

Japan at war

After years of turmoil, there was a revived sense of national identity and pride in Japan. The cry was not only "oitsuke, oikose" but also "fukoku kyohei" ("rich nation, strong army"). Japan was not to be toyed with. In the spring of 1894, Korea called for military aid from China to put down a rebellion. China obliged, and so did Japan. The rebellion was swiftly dealt with, but both sides had interests in Korea and stayed on. The Japanese were determined to fight, and officially declared war on August 1.

The Sino-Japanese War had begun. In the battles that followed, Japan proved superior, especially at sea. The naval base of Port Arthur in Manchuria, on the northeast coast of China, was seized in November, and the Chinese fleet destroyed at Weihai in the eastern province of Shandong in February 1895. The Treaty of Shimonoseki in April 1895 saw China abandon its interests in Korea and cede territory to Japan, including Taiwan. Japan also gained rights in Manchuria, which had rich natural resources of lumber, iron, oil, gold, and uranium.

This was the first major step in Japan's empire-building in Asia. Russia reacted by persuading the French and German governments that Japan should give up its stronghold in Manchuria because it caused instability. Japan bowed to pressure and reluctantly agreed. When Russia refused to withdraw its troops from China, following an uprising against foreign influences known as the Boxer Rebellion (see pp.354–55), the increasing tension with Russia eventually erupted into war in 1904.

Japan was by now an impressive military force, while Russia was severely disadvantaged by the 1905 Revolution (see pp.376–77). Japan was triumphant. The ensuing Portsmouth Treaty, signed in September 1905, recognized Japan's interests in Korea and granted them occupation of the Liaodong Peninsula in Manchuria. Japan quickly established control over Korea. It disbanded the army and annexed the nation in 1910 with no international opposition.

Japan had succeeded in its aims—it was now taken seriously by Western powers. The unequal treaties, which had caused so much bitterness, were revised and full tariff (customs) control restored in 1911. In a mere half-century, Japan had gone from being virtually dismissed as a backward country to a major world power.

As Japan entered the 20th century, it seemed stable. This soon changed. Economic depression and dissatisfaction with Japan's role in world affairs eventually led to war.

DISCONTENT

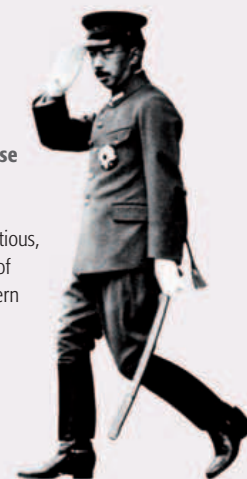
During World War I **372–73** >> industrial production grew fivefold and exports more than trebled in Japan. After the war, **prices collapsed and economic recession** set in. Rural incomes fell sharply and the gap between rich and poor, city and countryside widened. Both the military and public became increasingly angry, and many **blamed the influence of Western ideas.**

AN UNEASY ALLIANCE

Japan maintained an **uneasy relationship** with foreign powers. Japan attended the Versailles Peace Conference in 1919 **374–75** >> where the victors of World War I met to negotiate peace treaties with the defeated Germany. But **Japan did not always feel a true equal.** In 1920, Japan was one of the founding members of **the League of Nations 374–75** >>, which was set up to work toward disarmament and diplomacy, but it was upset that its proposal for a racial equality clause in the league's charter was rejected. To compound matters, the Washington Arms Limitation Treaty of 1922 limited Japan to three warships, compared with five American and five British.

NATIONALISM

After years of trying to gain respect abroad without success, **Japanese frustration** with Westerners **turned to contempt.** Fiercely ambitious, Japan was set on a path of confrontation with Western powers **402–03** >>.



EMPEROR HIROHITO OF JAPAN (1901–89)

“Enrich the country, strengthen the military.”

JAPAN'S NATIONAL SLOGAN DURING THE MEIJI ERA, 1868–1912



Modern power

A Japanese naval squadron is shown here steaming in to bombard Port Arthur, Manchuria, and attack Russian ships. During the Russo-Japanese war, Japan proved militarily superior, especially at sea.

DECISIVE MOMENT

THE MEIJI RESTORATION

After US naval officer Matthew Perry demanded the opening of Japanese ports in 1854, the shoguns seemed incapable of dealing with the foreign threat. A group of leading samurai (warriors) formed an alliance, believing that only the restoration of the emperor could save Japan. In 1868 a short civil war brought the nearly 700-year shogunate rule to an end. Emperor Mutsuhito was restored and a new era began. The period of modernization that followed was called the Meiji (1868–1912), but not all were content. In 1877 there was a major rebellion in Kyushu. Traditional forces, including samurai infuriated at being barred from carrying swords, were defeated by the new conscript army. The emperor promised a national assembly, and in 1889 the first-ever formal constitution adopted outside North America and Europe was proclaimed. In this woodcut, Meiji officers in Western-style uniforms are shown accepting the surrender of the samurai rebels.

